

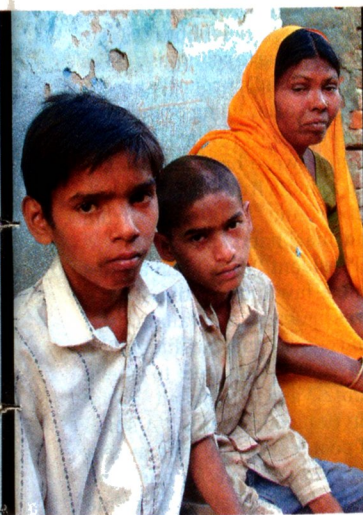


KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

'witches' being hunted even in non-tribal communities. On March 18, 2010, Quresa Khatun of Bokaro was hacked to death by her relative Mohammad Shakeel who suspected her of killing his daughter using her malevolent magical powers. In another gruesome incident, five non-tribal women, including three widows, were stripped and paraded naked in Deoghar district of Jharkhand last year after being accused of witchcraft. They survived because the police reached just in time.

Today Jharkhand has become a breeding ground for superstition, illiteracy and violence against women. Interestingly, such accusations are often made to grab property. Despite

MOST WOMEN ACCUSED OF BEING WITCHES ARE PUNISHED PUBLICLY



ASHOK PRIYADARSHI

Intolerable Cruelty

Source: National Crime Records Bureau

Witchcraft Murders	India	Jharkhand	Haryana	Andhra Pradesh	Orissa	Madhya Pradesh	Chhattisgarh	Bihar
2008	175	52	25	23	23	17	15	0
2007	177	50	30	33	28	14	8	0
2006	186	29	34	26	36	13	10	11
2005	197	26	28	75	25	13	9	1
2004	111	26	0	24	22	14	11	0
2003	140	19	0	37	26	26	9	0
2002	151	26	0	23	39	24	4	1
2001	126	21	2	20	30	13	14	1
Total	1263	249	119	261	229	134	80	14

despite the adoption of the Prevention of Witch Practices Act in 2001, speaks volumes about the issue.

At the national level, the NCRB fact-sheet on witchcraft killings has thrown up disconcerting numbers. Over 1,263 persons have been killed in the country during this period for practising "black magic". Ironically, the issue figures just as a footnote during debates on women empowerment. Apart from Jharkhand, Haryana has emerged as a standout

case worth an observation because of the conflicting signals emanating from the state. At the beginning of the decade, in fact from 2001 to 2004, Haryana remained almost alien to the concept of witch killings. In the next four years, from 2005 to 2008, the state witnessed killing of 117 witches, accounting for nearly 16 per cent of total such deaths occurring in the country during that period.

In Jharkhand, investigations reveal a disturbing pattern with

the witchcraft prevention act, its implementation has left a lot to be desired. Jharkhand Additional Director General of Police, CID, Gaurishankar Rath, says, "We have a special law, but we also need to have special courts and special prosecutors to expedite convictions in witchcraft cases and put them before the society as an effective deterrent." The conviction rate statistics in the state indisputably establishes why the law has failed to act as a deterrent. In fact, the NCRB